

The Dhāraṇī Called 'Granting Refuge to Hungry Ghosts Whose Mouths Blaze with Fire'

Mukhadarīmukhāgnipratīṣṭhā · Toh 646 · Derge Kangyur

ཡེ་དྲི་གསུམ་ཁ་ནས་མ་འེབར་བ་ལ་སྒྲུས་མཛད་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གི་ཟུངས།

Toh 646 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in English as "The Dhāraṇī Called Granting Refuge to Hungry Ghosts Whose Mouths Blaze with Fire," corresponding to the Sanskrit Mukhaṃ jvalantī nāma dhāraṇī and the Tibetan Yi dags kha nas me 'bar ba la skyabs mdzad pa zhes bya ba'i gzungs. It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and concerns the ritual use of sacred syllables and practices to relieve the suffering of hungry ghosts, a class of beings tormented by insatiable hunger and thirst, whose mouths burn with unquenchable fire. The text is framed as a teaching given by the Buddha at Śrāvastī, prompted by an encounter between the venerable Ānanda and one such anguished hungry ghost who warns him of impending death, setting in motion a search for means of liberation and relief. As a dhāraṇī scripture it combines narrative, protective formula, and ritual instruction, representing a genre of Buddhist literature devoted to the power of consecrated speech to benefit beings across multiple realms of existence.

The Dhāraṇī Called "Granting Refuge to Hungry Ghosts Whose Mouths Blaze with Fire"

At that time the Blessed One was in the land of Śrāvastī, dwelling in the residence of the Saṅgha, teaching the Dharma to a great assembly of monks and to an innumerable host of bodhisattvas gathered around him.

At that time the venerable Ānanda was sitting alone at one side, applying his mind to the Dharma and resting in mindfulness. Then, in the latter part of the night, a being called "Hungry Ghost Whose Mouth Blazes with Fire" — hideous in form, utterly thin and desiccated, with flames shooting from its mouth, its throat no wider than the eye of a needle, its hair matted and tangled, its nails and fangs long, and its ears utterly terrifying — came before Ānanda and spoke to him these words: "You will die in seven days from now and be reborn in the realm of hungry ghosts."

When Ānanda heard those words, he was seized with extreme fear and terror. He addressed the hungry ghost, saying: "If I am to die and be reborn in the realm of hungry ghosts, what means is there by which I might be completely liberated from that suffering?"

The hungry ghost then spoke to Ānanda: "If tomorrow you were to give food offerings to as many hungry ghosts as there are grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers, and were to offer supreme and excellent food to as many as a hundred thousand brahmins and ascetics — a full measure of the finest grain of the central lands for each one — and were to make offerings to the Three Jewels on my behalf, then you would live long, be freed from the suffering of the hungry ghost realm, and be reborn as a god in the higher realms."

At that point Ānanda both saw the hungry ghost whose mouth blazed with fire — hideous of body, utterly thin and desiccated, fire blazing from its mouth, throat no wider than the eye of a needle, hair tangled and matted, nails and fangs long and sharp — and heard those unwelcome and disturbing words, and was so terrified that his body shook like a shaken vessel. He rose and went swiftly to where the Blessed One was. Arriving in the presence of the Blessed One, he touched his five lower limbs to the ground, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One, and, his body trembling and tormented by suffering, besought him to be his protector and ally, addressing the Blessed One with these words:

"I was sitting alone at one side, applying my mind to the Dharma, when a being called 'Hungry Ghost Whose Mouth Blazes with Fire' came to me and said: 'In seven days you will certainly die and be reborn in the realm of hungry ghosts.' When I asked it what means there might be to be completely liberated from the suffering of the hungry ghost realm, it said to me: 'If you give food offerings to as many hungry ghosts as the grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers, and offer the finest and most excellent food to as many as a hundred thousand brahmins and ascetics and the like, you will live long.' But Blessed One, how could I possibly come to possess enough food for that many hungry ghosts, ascetics, and all the rest?"

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "Do not be afraid. I have a means by which food and many offering cakes can be made abundantly available to as many hungry ghosts as the grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers, and to brahmins, ascetics, and the like. Do not be disheartened."

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "I possess a dhāraṇī mantra called 'The Resplendent Victorious Ray of Light, Endowed with Boundless Majesty.' Whoever recites this dhāraṇī — the food offerings and offering cakes will

become supreme and excellent for as many hungry ghosts as there are grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers, and for the many brahmins, ascetics, and the like. Each one among them will receive seven full measures, measured by the measure of the finest grain of the central lands."

"Ānanda, when I too was once born as a brahmin, I heard this dhāraṇī from the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and the Tathāgata known as Controlling Virtue. Through the power of that, I gave food offerings and offering cakes to immeasurable hungry ghosts and to many ascetics. Those who had been born in the realm of hungry ghosts were fully liberated from suffering and were reborn as gods in the higher realms. Ānanda, take hold of this dhāraṇī. Merit and the measure of one's lifespan will increase and multiply."

At that time the Blessed One then declared to Ānanda this dhāraṇī mantra:

Namaḥ sarva-tathāgata-avalokite, oṃ sambhara sambhara hūṃ.

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "Whatever son of good family or daughter of good family wishes for long life, for great and increasing merit, and to swiftly and fully complete the perfection of generosity — if they do this constantly at the time of the early morning, or indeed at any time, there will be no interruption. Pour clean water into a clean vessel and add a small amount of sesame oil, or flour, or barley, or the like. Place the right hand over the vessel, recite this dhāraṇī seven times, and then invoke the names of the four Tathāgatas.

Homage to the Tathāgata Many Jewels. Through the blessing of invoking the name of the Tathāgata Many Jewels, the non-virtuous karma accumulated through miserliness over the many lifetimes of all hungry ghosts will be destroyed, and merit will be fully perfected.

Homage to the Tathāgata Excellent Form. Through the blessing of invoking the name of the Tathāgata Excellent Form, the many hungry ghosts will have their ugly and repulsive appearances destroyed, and they will become endowed with excellent form and marks.

Homage to the Tathāgata Vast Body. Through the blessing of invoking the name of the Tathāgata Vast Body, the thirst of many hungry ghosts will be dispelled, and they will be satisfied. From the place of generosity they will eat and be content and replete, as they wish.

Homage to the Tathāgata Free from Fear. Through the blessing of invoking the name of the Tathāgata Free from Fear, the many hungry ghosts will be separated from all fears, and all the realms of hungry ghosts will be pacified."

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "Sons of good family and the rest should invoke the names of the four Tathāgatas, and after the blessing, snap the fingers three times, take up the vessel of offering cakes, extend the arm, and pour the contents onto a clean patch of ground. When the offering cakes are given in this way, hungry ghosts who have gathered from the four directions — as many as there are grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers — will each individually receive seven full measures, measured by the measure of the finest grain of the central lands. Having eaten that food as they wish, being content and replete, they will abandon the realm of hungry ghosts and be reborn as gods in the higher realms.

Ānanda, if any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman constantly consecrates food with this dhāraṇī and gives it to hungry ghosts, immeasurable merit will be fully perfected — indeed, it will be no different from the merit of making offerings to as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers. Long life, merit, radiance, and strength will be born and will increase; the roots of virtue will be fully perfected; humans and non-humans, yakṣas, rākṣasas, malevolent hungry ghosts — none of these will be able to harm or injure them;"

and they will be possessed of immeasurable splendor before others.

If someone wishes to make an offering to brahmins and seers (ṛṣis), let them fill a single clean vessel with pure food, recite this dhāraṇī mantra seven times, and pour it into a clean, flowing stream. By doing so, that food will become the most supremely excellent divine ambrosia. Those brahmins and seers who receive the mantra-consecrated food will, through the blessing of the mantra, each have their roots of virtue fully perfected — all the virtuous roots corresponding to whatever they had previously delighted in and aspired toward — and one may pray: "May each of them, in accordance with their own inclinations, at this very time be endowed with long life, radiance, and strength, and may they dwell in happiness and well-being."

Furthermore, that person will see and hear things exactly as their mind intends, will become utterly pure through the doors of vision and hearing, will possess unerring knowledge, and will be possessed of and completely perfect

in the supreme conduct of Brahmā (the god of purity).

Furthermore, this is equal to the merit of making offerings to as many Blessed One buddhas as there are grains of sand in tens of thousands of hundreds of thousands of Ganges Rivers. No adversary whatsoever will be able to cause them harm.

If any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman wishes to make offerings to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, let them recite this dhāraṇī mantra twenty-one times over incense, flowers, and excellent food, and then present them to the Three Jewels. The food so offered by that son or daughter of good family will thereby become divine ambrosia, and will count as having made offerings to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha throughout the world-realms of the ten directions. They will thus be endowed with the merit of praise, supplication, and rejoicing, and will always be extolled and held in mind by the Blessed One buddhas. They will always be guarded and protected by the many gods, and the perfection of generosity will be fully completed.

Ānanda, from this day forward, keep this Dharma in mind as is proper, teach it and spread it widely so that all sentient beings may see and hear it, and you will thereby obtain merit beyond measure.

The mouths of the hungry ghosts—

Translator's Notes

- The text names the interlocutor as "the venerable Ānanda" (Tib. Tshe dang ldan pa Dga' bo), which is the standard Tibetan rendering of Āyusmān Ānanda. The name Dga' bo literally means "Joyful One," which is a calque of Ānanda, so it is rendered throughout as Ānanda.

The phrase "yul dbus 'gyur tshal gyi bre tshad ma" refers to a specific volumetric measure used in the middle country of India, translated here as "a full measure of the finest grain of the central lands." The exact capacity of this measure is not specified in the text and would depend on regional convention; the translation reflects the text's comparative framing without inventing a quantity.

- The epithet "Controlling Virtue" (dBang sgyur yon tan) for a Tathāgata is a name appearing in preta-offering ritual literature; no Sanskrit back-formation is certain, so it is rendered by meaning only.

The phrase rendered "snap the fingers" (se gol lan gsum byas te) literally means making the finger-snapping gesture three times, a standard ritual action in this context.

- The passage ends mid-sentence, cutting off at "The mouths of the hungry ghosts." This is a continuation break; the sentence resumes in the following passage. The phrase rendered "divine ambrosia" translates lha rdzas kyi zhal zas, literally "the food of divine substances," a standard term for celestial nourishment. The rendering "brahmins and seers" follows the Tibetan bram ze dang drang srong, the standard pairing of brahmin and ṛṣi.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.